



VertiGO!!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 705 November 2007 PO BOX 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

Club nights are at Turnbull House, on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea and coffee afterwards. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher public bar at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up.



Section Night 5 November 2007: Erik Bradshaw “Unexpected Adventures in the Himalayas”

It started as a simple adventure – ski tour from Manali along the Himalaya to the starting point of the Ganges – about 300km. However, the biggest snow year in memory, bad weather, running out of food and being saved by snowbound villages led to a truly great adventure! Even the local Buddhist monastery had never heard of people coming over the passes in winter and they have been there for thousands of years!



NB: First Section Night 4 February 2008

The first section night for 2008 will be held at Fergs. Admission will be free to Club members and there will also be a BBQ. We will need some help on the BBQ (free sausages) so please contact Blair on bh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz if you are keen to help out.



Daniel Thomas descending Aiguille Le Tour, France



Section Trip News

Please send all your fantastic trip reports to
newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories.



Chamonix Adventures July '07

Living and working as a volunteer at the International Scout Centre in Kandersteg, Switzerland allows a great deal of time to play in the Alps. Since becoming a member of NZAC a few years ago, its time to send an update to those members that know me about the latest adventures I have been lucky enough to experience.

In late July we took a few days off work and headed to the Chamonix Valley for some classic alpine climbing. Having spent some time in the valley in 2004, skiing the Vallee Blanche, and on several rock climbing trips, it was time now to experience these mountains on a higher level.

Four of us travelled over together. A Kiwi, a Brit, a German and a Dane. What a mix of nationalities, cultures and experiences. We joined two other Brits at the campsite and the guide books came out and the planning began.

The first day of activity saw me paired up with my normal climbing partner in the Alps, Mustard from the UK. We decided to tackle an alpine route called Chappelle de La Gliere. 2663m. Graded at AD+ the South Ridge is a fairly straight forward rock route that begins by taking the Flégère cable car and chairlift, followed by a short hike past Le Index and up a short scree slope to the start of the route.

The route is long, made even longer by consistent waits at each belay point for other groups and guides to move on. French mountain guides don't tend to let faster climbers by-pass them, especially when the other climbers are speaking to them in English.

We climbed very solid, steep rock for a few pitches, and continued climbing the ridge gradually getting more exposure up to the huge 'sharks fin' at around 2400m. A very exposed traverse across the sharks fin (which I was pleased not to be leading) takes you to a saddle before the last two pitches to the summit.

As a result of how busy the route was, and a very long wait in the saddle, we could not complete the final pitch of about 6m and summit, but instead abseiled off, returned to camp to organise kit, and get out again.

Later that afternoon we took the Le Tour - Charamillon gondola, and had a short pleasant hike to the Albert Premier Hut with every intention of bivvy-ing out for the night near the hut. As the perfect storm rolled in and the hut rattled and shook with the thunder, we decided that sleeping in the picnic room of the hut was a better option.

An early alpine start the next morning and the storm had passed. Onto the glacier and once again roped up with Mustard, we headed for Aiguille. Le Tour. 3544m. We decided to take the route Couloir de Table which is graded at AD-. A very pleasant climb up the couloir with almost perfect firm packed snow the whole way made kicking steps an easy task. The ridge up top was dry with excellent rock conditions on the traverse to the summit.

A fast descent to the hut was followed by a relaxing afternoon at the campsite, to catch up on the experiences of the other members of the party.

The third and final day involved a simple crag day at Les Chavants, in a relaxed part of the Chamonix valley, all the time with the Mt Blanc Massif as the back drop. Quickly we knocked up a half dozen routes each before the afternoon alpine storms came in and we drove the hour and a half back to our little village in the Swiss Alps.

Living in the Alps works well for all my hobbies. Winter and summer activities never go amiss and all members and friends are welcome to get in contact with me if they are heading to Europe in the next 18 months and want to get amongst it for a few days.

Dan Thomas

kiwidanthomas@yahoo.co.nz



Taranaki 21-23 September 07

Another chance to climb Egmont? “hell yes”! I thought, looking at the upcoming club trips on the sections web site it was the perfect opportunity to make up for the last weekend of the AIC 07 course.

With the weekend getting nearer the E-Mails sent from the trip leader Marc Heatley revealed the original party of eight was getting smaller by the day and so by the time of departure we were down to an uneven number of five. Or a tight five as Marc preferred to call it. The tight five were: Wellington contingent: Marc Heatley, Mark Macdonald, Robert Pamer and from the Wairarapa: Alec Dondertman and Glen Millar.

After meeting at the North Egmont car park we proceeded to make our way up the notorious 4WD track, a 600m walk that had us heavy breathing, puffing and sweating all the way to our destination - Tahurangi Lodge. If there was any highlight from that walk it would be that it was a very mild night with great visibility from the moon so we walked the whole way to the lodge by moonlight. On arrival we were amazed to find that there was no one else staying there so we spread out accordingly and made the most of it.

Saturday morning we woke to find a clear fine day with little wind and a view right to the top. Knowing the mountains reputation for rapidly changing weather there was no time to waste and we quickly got our gear together and headed up the mountain. We pushed as far as we could up the lizard before it became too hard under foot and we stopped to make the transition to crampons. From then on it was nothing but a slow but steady slog up the unrelenting slope of the North ridge. At that angle you know that it can't go on forever and before long the lip of the summit entrance came into view. The hard work had been done and we pushed on over into the crater to find that we weren't the only ones on the mountain, a couple of locals were having a bite to eat in the sun and preparing to do some ice climbing on one of the many icy outcrops that surround the crater. They had summited via the East ridge.

From there it was a quick five minute climb up onto the summit. A steady cold breeze up top meant we didn't hang around for long, time for a few quick photos before heading back into the crater for some lunch.

Before heading back down we reminded ourselves of the icy conditions and the consequences that a fall could bring but to our surprise the warm day had softened up the slope and the walking was very fast and safe. In fact the conditions were just right for a couple of our party to perfect their bum sliding technique, a practice that I'm sure is frowned upon by many pure mountaineers. Naturally no names are mentioned. Robert had his own method of getting down fast and so took his crampons off quite high up and equipped with two ski poles proceeded to ski down on his boots! A skill he no doubt picked up back in his native homeland of Germany.

So after a quick descent taking only one hour we were soon back at the lodge. Obviously after having not received enough exercise Robert headed out again to explore the ski field over to the East while the others were content enough to put their feet up and savour some refreshments that had laboriously been hauled up the night before.

After another night in the still empty lodge we packed our gear early, donned wet weathers for the now bleak conditions and headed back down to the car park for the five hour return journey home.

Egmont/Taranaki was a most enjoyable weekend trip which can be described as being a relatively easy walk but a good chance to practice the alpine skills learnt from AIC on the mountains steep slope and mixed conditions.



Robert with ski poles ascending



Tahurangi Peak & First Finger Gully August '07

25 – 26 August 2007 – Neville Palmer, Gavin Marshall, Jason Brown, Ali Bryant, Frances Woodhead, Mark Yeo and Trey Guinn.

After at least a week of stunning weather it was with a little apprehension towards the weather forecast for the weekend that we found ourselves driving towards Ohakune on Friday night. It was looking like Saturday would be ok for climbing but Sunday was likely to be a café day.

We woke on Saturday morning to light drizzle, still not convinced of the weather. We soon found there was no need for concern. Just a few metres above the Turoa car park, the sun was out above the blanket of cloud, with a clear blue sky and barely a puff of wind. The conditions were the best I'd seen in my short history with Ruapehu.

We had already decided that a summit of Tahurangi really only counted if we started from the carpark. No chairlift for us today. (OK so the guide book says the Skyline Ridge route starts at Blyth Hut but who's really counting?) We didn't get far before crampons were off packs and on our boots. Even the snow was in good nick for climbing. Things were shaping up well.

There was an interesting mix of abilities in the team and with the fantastic conditions everyone found a little of something to test themselves on, on the way to the summit. Unfortunately, due to a little misdirection by their trusty leader, Gavin, Jason, Ali and Frances missed the ridge approach to the summit and ended up at the col below steep ice on the northern side of the summit peak. No-one was overly concerned by this as we enjoyed a leisurely lunch over looking the Crater Lake. After lunch Ali joined Trey & I, to retrace our steps and claim her summit shot.

By this time the snow had softened just enough that all thoughts of decorum were lost and, much to the amusement of the ant trail of snow boarders and skiers now making their way up the mountain for an off-piste run, the only way down for us was bum-sliding and shovel-sliding. It was a hilarious end to a great day. Then back below the cloud to the rain and grey of Ohakune.

Sunday morning started very much the same with drizzle and cloud in Ohakune and glorious sun on the mountain. Our original trip plan had been to climb Girdlestone on the second day. However, looking across from Tahurangi on Saturday, there were some impressive ice formations around the summit which looked to make the climb a little more challenging than we had anticipated. Not everyone in the team had harnesses and ropes so we decided to leave Girdlestone for next time. Instead we found some small ice cliffs just above and east of the Giant Café, named First Finger gully. We may not have had enough harnesses, ropes and gear for everyone to climb a peak but there was more than enough for us all to have a play on some steeper ice. For most of us there were a lot of things to put into practice for the first time; climbing with two tools, placing a first ice screw, setting up anchors, leading a pitch. I think we all learnt a lot and had a ball in the process.

No one really wanted to leave the mountain that afternoon but there was still the drive back to Wellington. So we dragged ourselves away from our playground and headed back below the overcast sky to Ohakune for a quick bite at the Mountain Rocks before hitting the road for home.

Neville Palmer



Andrew's Adventures

Andrew Finnigan was a student on AIC in 2004 (Garth London was his instructor). Since doing AIC, Andrew has gone on to complete some amazing climbs and is now working towards training as a guide in Mt Cook, spending this summer guiding Ball Pass. Here is a snippet from Andrew's adventures since completing AIC:

'This is pretty steep...If this is grade 1, I can't imagine a grade 3! I thought mountains had snow on them, not this stuff. Why are we walking in a big dangerous, expensive circle in a whiteout? I wonder if I will ever manage to climb a 3000m mountain?'

A sample of my thoughts as I tentatively weaved through the classic Taranaki sastrugi during AIC 2004. I was working for the Wellington City Council; my first year out of university, a civil engineering degree behind me.

Something had driven me to take a childhood of tramping to the next level and onto the white stuff. At the time I had no idea where it was going to lead.

Well now, in 2007 it has changed everything. A half-hearted engineering career is now history and the mountains are both my work and play. After AIC, Manu Ward, Shane Harrison

and I (all 2004 AIC-ers) visited one of the volcanoes whenever the weather allowed. A climb of Tapu-ae-nuku was our first South Island trip and attempts on Earnslaw and Sealy took us to the bigger mountains. The lure of the hills was too strong and I moved to Timaru racking up loads of moderate ascents over that year.

Despite the massive scope for climbing in NZ I was tempted by the Himalayas and took part in an Adventure Consultants, 3 peaks expedition to Nepal. The trip was fantastic but a little tame and on return I decided it was time to get out in NZ's big mountains. I took the summer off and climbed Mts Aspiring, Cook, Dixon, Hooker and Madeline.

I was beginning to wonder if I should make a living out of climbing and a position with Franz Josef Glacier Guides provided a perfect entry level position in the guiding world. The job was alright but the weekends were amazing. Being right there and well looked after by The Heli Line saw me in the Neves a couple of times a month. Climbs of the Moonshine Buttress on Conway, Jungle Drums on Spencer, Tigger on Barnicote, and the left couloir of Douglas showed me I was capable of technical climbing.

At this point the bank account was again flush and I found 4 others for a trip to Peru. We spent 2 months climbing with ascents of 8 peaks between 5500m-6800m including the quite rightly world famous Alpamayo.

I am guiding Ball Pass this summer and plan to begin the NZMGA guides assessments the summer after this.

There are loads of great things about AIC but two jump to mind. Its location and the contacts. A professional TMC in the Southern alps can never match AIC as a place to find climbing buddies. Aussies fill most of those expensive courses and will never be the regular weekend warriors that AIC is full of. The location is also perfect. The larger more dangerous mountains are a long way away! This might seem like a bad thing but weekends spent on the North Island volcanoes are the beginning of an often overlooked climbing apprenticeship. AIC is awesome, get into it, crawl all over those volcanoes, plan some trips south and then there are no limits.

Let me know if you're down south and need someone on the other end of the rope.

Huge thanks to everyone past and present who has put time into AIC.

Andrew Finnigan



NATIONAL OFFICE REQUEST

NATIONAL OFFICE REQUEST - Old Annual Reports

As part of our ongoing sorting, it has come to light that our Hocken Archive Collection and National Reference Library are missing copies of our Annual Reports as follows:

Archive: Pre 1963, 64,65,66,68,69,78,79,83,87,89,93

Library: Pre 1998 (except 1981)

Please have a look to see if you have any old copies stashed away that you may be able to help us out with. They can be sent to Margaret at NZAC, PO Box 456, Christchurch Mail Centre 8140

Thank you



CLIMBING CAMPS



Hopkins Climbing Camp 2008

Register before December 1, help the organisers and avoid a late fee!

Go on day climbs / scrambles / tramps / mountain bike rides or longer multi – day trips to some major climbing destinations like the Dasler Pinnacles, Mt Strauchan or Mt Ward

When? – 29 December 2007 - 6 January, 2008

Where? – Huxley Lodge, Hopkins River.

Costs? - \$40 for individuals plus accommodation.

What to do when you get there?

Check out the information pack on-line at www.alpineclub.org.nz

See you there!



Taranaki Climbing Camp

Early Bird Registration ends December 1

Good alpine rock offers fantastic trad climbing within a brief walk of the camp. Go tramping in the Goblin Forest or alpine trekking with technical difficulty being anything you desire.

The most spectacular backdrops ever encountered with views out to Ruapehu, the Kaikoura Ranges and the Tasman Sea.

When? – 18 -23 January

Where? – Manganui Lodge, East Taranaki

Costs? - \$15 for individuals plus accommodation.

What to do when you get there?

Check out the information pack on-line at www.alpineclub.org.nz

See you there!



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AND HERE ARE THE CLUB TRIPS

Wellington Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the section, so if anyone has an idea about a trip, no matter how vague, send an email to trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz).

Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email us, or approach us at the monthly meeting, and we can help you get going.

Trips for the Calendar for 2007 so far...

11-18Nov07 - Centennial - Leader = Garth London - Level = AIC Graduate and 0-3 years experience – **ONE OR TWO PLACES AVAILABLE!**

Most likely we will be taking the ferry (Interislander) on Friday night then driving Reefton. Then on to Fox the next day. Plan is to chopper in to Centennial Hut. A number of options are possible including The Minarets, De La Beche. Contact Garth gl@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz

29Dec07 – 6Jan08 – Annual National NZAC Climbing Camp – Hopkins Valley

South Canterbury – Based at Huxley Lodge at the head of Lake Ohau – next major valley south of Mt Cook NP. This is a an excellent opportunity to “buddy-up” with other aspiring climbers at a marvellous location. Good access to several major snow and rock peaks including Mt Ward, Mt Jackson, Glen Isla and of course the Daisler Pinnacles (recently featured in Climber). For the information pack pdf (23KB) [click here](#). For further information including registration see the National NZAC website for details - <http://www.alpineclub.org.nz/default.aspx?p=358>. Contact Kevin kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz for car pooling arrangements from Wellington.

18-23Jan08 – NZAC North Island Rock Climbing Camp – Mt Egmont (Taranaki).

Based at Stratford Mountain Lodge (1300m) 20 minutes walk from the road end. Good alpine rock offers fantastic trad climbing within a short walk of the lodge. For the information pack pdf (23KB) [click here](#). Be in quick, only 33 places available! For further information including registration see the National NZAC website for details - <http://www.alpineclub.org.nz/default.aspx?p=362>. Contact Kevin kp@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz for car pooling arrangements from Wellington.

8-10Feb08 – Taranaki Rock – Leader = James Wright

Weekend trip to climb the rock on Mt Taranaki. Most likely we will be based from Tahurangi lodge on the Northern Slopes. Multiple rock routes on various pillars and outcrops including Humphries Castle. Contact James Wright at james.wright@extra.co.nz or call at (04) 232-7748 or (027) 4725-561.

May08 - Frog Buttress, Queensland – Leader = Rachel Schmidt

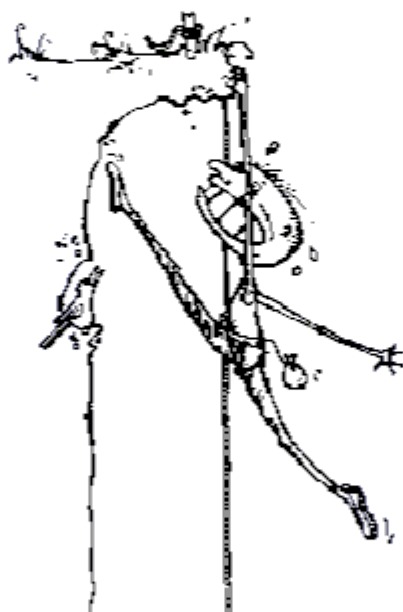
4 days - in and out Brisbane, followed by 4 days surfing/diving on North Stradbroke Island for those who want to come, otherwise those who want to just climb, can come for the first 4 days. Primo granite as recently featured in Climber (Sep07 issue). Contact Rachael rs@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz.



Wellington Section Directory: 2007 contact list

Position	Name	E-mail Alias*	Phone
Patron			
Chairperson	Garth London	CHAIRPERSON <i>or</i> GL	(04) 479 2984
Vice Chairperson	Jennifer Brown	JB2	027 292 0903
Secretary	Rachel Depree	SECRETARY <i>or</i> RD	N/A
Treasurer	Karen Domaneschi	TREASURER <i>or</i> KD	N/A
National Representative	Jennifer Brown and James Wright	JB2 <i>or</i> JW	N/A
	Garth London and Judy Reid	GL <i>or</i> JR	(04) 479 2984 (Garth)
Instruction: AIC	Rachael Schmidt	RS <i>or</i> AIC	N/A
Instruction: RIC	Blair Hiscoke	SPRINGROCK	N/A
National Instruction Rep	Rachael Schmidt	RS	N/A
Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	KF	N/A
Trips	Kevin Patterson	TRIPS <i>or</i> KP	N/A
	Gwen Rashbrooke	TRIPS <i>or</i> GR	N/A
Library	Derek Richardson	LIBRARY	N/A
	Peter Shanahan	PS2	N/A
Committee Members	Hayden Cox	HC	N/A
	Paul Grimwood	PG	N/A
	Pete de Joux	PD	N/A
	Blair Hiscoke	BH	N/A
	Louise Thornley	LT	N/A
	James Wright	JW	027 472 5561
	Catherine Moger	CM2	N/A
Newsletter Editor	Rachael Schmidt	NEWSLETTER <i>or</i> RS	N/A
Webmeister	Jane Furkert	WEBMASTER <i>or</i> JF	N/A
National President	Phil Doole		N/A

* Email address is alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, eg: secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



If undelivered please return to:

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